ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

University of Glasgow

Taking Words to Pieces

Marc Alexander

English Language & Linguistics 2A, Week 3

1

ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

What Is a Morpheme?

2



3



4

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

‘Base’ or ‘Root’

Carries main meaning, often a morpheme that can stand on its own

5

un- help -ful -ness

car -s

read -able

pre- view

‘Affix’

Can’t stand on its own, carries additional meaning

6

Three Types of Words

- Simple
- Complex
- Compound

7

Simple

- A base/root on its own
  - *car*
  - *green*
  - *avocado*
  - *on*

8

Complex

- A base/root with one or more bound morphemes (like affixes)
  - *driver*
  - *bilingual*
  - *subway*
  - *likely*
  - *education*

9

Compound

- Multiple bases/roots
  - *overcook*
  - *stirfry*
  - *dryclean*
  - *sky-high*
  - *signwriter*

10

Warnings!

- Do not confuse word length with number of morphemes!
  - *catamaran*
  - *knickerbocker*
  - *tenths* (*ten -th -s*)
- Do not confuse number of syllables with number of morphemes!
  - *car/cars*
  - *cardigan, avocado*

11

ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

Types of Morphemes

12

Free and Bound

Free

Free to be used as independent words on their own, can be the base/root of a compound or complex word

(Most bases are free – but not all!)

Bound

Cannot exist on their own and must be **bound** to another morpheme to make a word

(All affixes are bound, but there are other types of bound morphemes!)

13

Bound Morphemes

Affix

Bound Base

Cran-

14

Affix

- Must be added to a base
- Can be prefix, suffix, or (rarely) infix
  - *love, lovely*
  - *sense, nonsense*
  - *capable, incapable, incapability*
  - *absolutely, absofuckinglutely*

15

Affix: Plurals

How much do people notice a borrowed plural?

Nobody notices	→	**Nobody minds**	→	**Some people wince**	→	**Everyone notices**
oxen *agenda* *formulae*		*supernovae* *supernovas*		*millennia* *millenniums* *platypuses*		*dogmata*

formulas or formulae? forums or fora?

16

Bound Base

- A base which cannot stand on its own but requires some affix
- Carries lexical meaning
  - *dexterity*, **dexter*
  - *reject*, **ject*
  - *produce, deduce, reduce, induce*, **duce*

17

Bound Base

Look at these two sets of words, some of which have similar meanings but **a** has free bases and **b** has bound bases. Is there anything you notice about **a** and **b** compared to each other?

a: *readable hearing enlarge performance whiteness darken seeker*

b: *legible audience magnify rendition clarity obfuscate applicant*

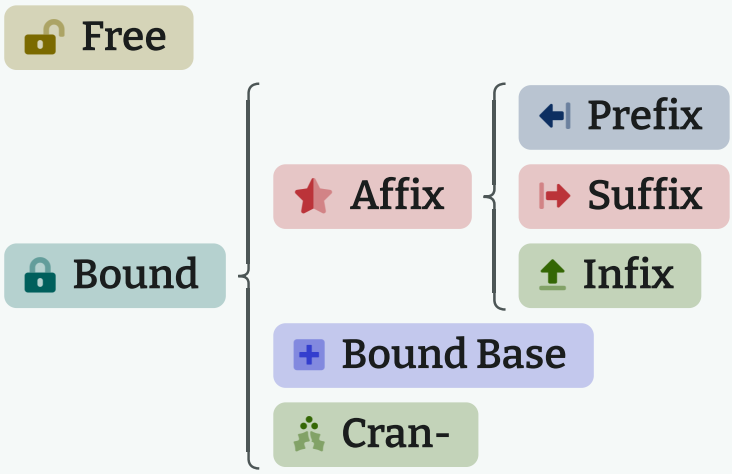
18

Cran-

- Bound morphemes which are entirely unproductive and are limited to one word
  - *cranberry*
  - *huckleberry*
  - *gormless*
  - *cobweb*
  - *lukewarm*

19

Free and Bound Morphemes



20

Libfixes

A liberated affix

- a piece of an existing word breaks free and becomes a productive affix, usually a suffix
- *spectacular* → *-tacular* *alcoholic* → *-holic*

The term

- Arnold Zwicky, 2010: *liberated* + *affix*
- *libfix* is now itself in the Cambridge Dictionary

21

Libfixes

coined before 2015

Euro-	Europe	*Europhile, Eurosceptic, Eurocentric*
-tacular	spectacular	*spooktacular, craptacular*
-tastic	fantastic	*funtastic, craptastic*
-holic	alcoholic	*chocoholic, pastaholic, yogaholic*
-dar	radar	*gaydar, geekdar, sarcasmdar, dogdar*
-gate	Watergate	*Partygate, Signalgate*
-gasm	orgasm	*braingasm, eargasm, eyegasm, foodgasm*
-licious	delicious	*soda-licious, bootylicious*
-mageddon	Armageddon	*snowmageddon, carmageddon, toemageddon*
-verse	universe	*multiverse, blogoverse, Twitterverse*

22

Libfixes
more recent

-core	hardcore	*normcore, cottagecore, Barbiecore*
-pilled	red pill	*fish-oil-pilled, Letterboxd-pilled*
-maxxing	looksmaxxing	*proteinmaxxing, tokenmaxxing*
-ussy		ADS Word of the Year 2022
-dle		ADS Digital Word of the Year 2022

23

Libfixes

-licious

Older than you think

> 'Oh! but this is soda-licious!'

New York Observer and Chronicle, 3 January 1878

By 1911, drug stores in Ada, Oklahoma and Fort Wayne, Indiana advertise *soda-licious* drinks

A Victorian libfix, not an internet one

-dar

A fragment of a fragment

radar = RAdio Detecting And Ranging, so *-dar* is a piece of an acronym

gaydar popularised it; then *geekdar, sarcasmdar, dogdar*

... and nundar

-gate

Fifty years of scandal

Watergate (1972): an office building in Washington DC

Partygate (2021)

Signalgate (2025)

English had no short productive way to name a scandal

24

Libfixes

Productivity is temporary

Hot	→	Stable	→	Cooling	→	Historic, alive	→	Used and died
-core *-pilled* *-maxxing* *-ussy*		*-gate* *-gasm* *-holic*		*-mageddon* *-verse* *-tacular*		*-licious*		*quaran-*

quaran- ADS Most Creative, 2020: *quarantini, quaranteam, quaranbeard*. Gone within 18 months.

Which of the 'hot' will still be productive in 2036...?

25

ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

How Are Morphemes Used?

26

So Why...?

- Why do we use morphemes?
  - Economy!
- How do we use English morphemes?
  - Lexeme formation
  - Inflection

27

Changes

happy + *un-* → unhappy	MEANING CHANGE Aj → Aj ‘negative of Aj’
amuse + *-ment* → amusement	CATEGORY CHANGE V → N
wash + *-able* → washable	MEANING AND CATEGORY CHANGE V → Aj ‘able to be Ved’

28

Some Changes

Some meaning changes

Aj → Aj 'negative Aj'
happy → unhappy

N → N 'place where N lives'
orphan → orphanage

V → V 'repeat V'
wash → rewash

Some category changes

V → N
amuse → amusement

V → Aj
impress → impressive

N → Aj
monster → monstrous

29

A Puzzle

respect	→	*disrespect*	
satisfied	→	*dissatisfied*	
ease	→	*disease*	
proper	→	*improper*	not **disproper*
pertinent	→	*impertinent*	not **dispertinent*

30

Restrictions on Affixes

Etymological

-en will attach to native bases but not Latinate bases, *-ic* will only attach to French/Latin bases

Categorical

-ity can only be added to Aj, *-ize* to N or Aj, *un-* to Aj or V

Phonological

-ize prefers N and Aj bases of two or more syllables with no primary stress on the final syllable, while *-en* (Aj → V) attaches only to bases ending in plosives, fricatives, and affricates

Syntactic

-able attaches to transitive verbs

Semantic

un- can only be added to bases not already negative in meaning

31

Inflection

- As well as lexeme formation, morphemes help *inflect* English
  - Signal grammatical relationships
- Comparatively rare in English
  - Nouns (3 types)
  - Verbs (5 types)
  - Adjectives/Adverbs (3 types)
  - Remember, inflection isn't *just* morphology (eg *she/her*)

32

ENGLISH WORDS
History, Meaning, and Structure

University of Glasgow

Taking Words to Pieces

Marc Alexander

English Language & Linguistics 2A, Week 3

33